

IELTS Writing Task 2: Cause & Effect Essays

What the question asks

A cause-and-effect prompt asks you to explain why something happens and what follows from it. Both halves must appear: an essay that lists causes but never reaches consequences answers only part of the task.

Structure

1. Introduction - paraphrase the prompt, state the scope.
2. Body 1 - the main causes, each explained, not just named.
3. Body 2 - the effects that follow, linked back to the causes.
4. Conclusion - restate the relationship in one sentence.

Language of causation

Cause: stems from, is driven by, arises from, is triggered by

Effect: leads to, results in, gives rise to, contributes to

Hedging: is likely to, tends to, may in part explain

Common mistakes

- Naming a symptom as if it were a cause.
- Listing four causes with one line each instead of two developed with an example.
- Claiming certainty where the evidence supports a tendency.

Practice prompt

In many countries the number of people living alone is rising.

What are the causes of this trend, and what effects does it have on society? Write at least 250 words.